THREE-QUARTERS GREEN

A Novel

Blake Pierce

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This is a work of fiction.

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CHAPTER ONE

THREE-QUARTERS GREEN

“Daddy, how come you ain’t paintin’ that end?”

Alan Farmer—Lake’s Daddy—scraped the brush around the bottom of the five-gallon bucket. The bristles came up mint green, but barely.

“’Cause I ain’t got no more paint.”

Lake leaned over the bucket.

“There’s some down in there.”

“Well, git it out.”

Lake crouched beside him and studied the thin puddle.

“I can’t.”

“Neither can I.”

Alan wiped what was left onto the side of the twelve-by-sixty mobile home.

Three-quarters of it was mint green.

The rest was weathered white, with rust showing through in places.

Lake backed into the yard and tilted his head.

“Looks kinda funny.”

Alan stepped back beside him.

“You buyin’ more paint?”

“I ain’t got no money.”

“Neither do I.”

Lake stared at the trailer.

“Where’d you git this paint?”

“Factory was throwin’ it away.”

“They just give it to ya?”

“Yep.”

Lake looked at the green part. Then the white part.

“Well, reckon green and white looks pretty good together.”

Alan nodded.

“That’s what I was thinkin’.”

The screen door slapped open behind them.

Lake’s Momma, Collette, leaned through it.

“Y’all gonna stand out there admirin’ that thing all day or come eat?”

“We’re comin’.”

Lake started toward the door.

“Boy.”

He stopped.

Alan pointed toward the paint bucket.

“You carried it out here.”

Lake sighed.

“I know.”

“Well?”

“I’m gittin’ it.”

“You ain’t gittin’ nothin’. You’re standin’ there.”

“Dadgummit.”

“What was that?”

“Nothin’.”

“That’s what I thought.”

Lake grabbed the bucket.

The bottom of the trailer was enclosed with pieces of particle board Alan had fitted together for underpinning. Some pieces matched. Most didn't.

Lake kicked one as he passed.

"Quit kickin' that."

"I barely touched it."

"You touch it hard enough to knock it loose, you're crawlin' under there to put it back."

Lake stopped kicking.

Inside were two bedrooms, one bathroom, a little kitchen and a living room.

At least that was how the trailer had started.

Alan had divided the children's bedroom in half. A narrow passage ran between the two little rooms. Lake had one side. His little sister Sue—four years younger and Punkin to everybody who knew her—had the other.

There wasn't room for beds.

There were blankets folded into pallets on the floor.

Lake dropped the bucket by the door.

"Wash your hands," Collette said.

"They ain't dirty."

She looked at them.

Lake looked too.

Mint-green paint covered two fingers.

"Well, they wasn't dirty a minute ago."

"Wash 'em."

"Yes, ma'am."

Punkin sat at the table waiting.

Lake stuck his green fingers toward her.

"I'm turnin' into the house."

Punkin giggled.

“You’re stupid.”

“Am not.”

“Are too.”

“Am not.”

“Both of y’all hush and eat.”

Alan sat down.

A little television played in the living room. The picture rolled once, settled, then filled with a man behind a news desk talking about Americans being held somewhere called Iran.

* * *

Lake twisted around in his chair.

“Where’s Iran?”

Alan kept eating.

“Over yonder somewhere.”

“Where?”

“Long ways.”

“Farther than St. Louis?”

Alan looked at him.

“Yeah, Lake. Farther than St. Louis.”

On the television, the newsman spoke about President Carter and the hostages. Collette reached over and turned the volume down.

“Eat before it gets cold.”

Lake looked around the table.

“Daddy?”

“What?”

“When we gittin’ a bigger house?”

Alan took a bite.

“What’s wrong with this’un?”

“My room ain’t got no bed.”

“You got somewhere to sleep, don’t ya?”

“Yeah.”

“You got your own room, don’t ya?”

“Yeah.”

“Then sounds pretty big to me.”

Lake looked down the little hallway.

“Punkin ain’t allowed in my room.”

“I am too!”

“No you ain’t.”

Collette pointed her fork at them.

“Eat.”

Lake grinned.

On television, Iran gave way to a commercial for a new car that shined under lights brighter than anything in the Farmer house.

Lake watched it.

“Daddy, why don’t we git one of them?”

Alan didn’t even turn around.

“You got new-car money?”

“No.”

“Me neither.”

Collette shook her head.

“Boy, you think your daddy and me started out with money?”

Lake looked at her.

“Didn’t you?”

Alan laughed.

“Your mama and me were seventeen years old when you come along. We barely knew what we was doin’ ourselves.”

Collette looked across the table at him.

“Speak for yourself.”

Alan grinned.

“See there? Still don’t.”

Lake laughed. Punkin did too, even though she was too little to understand what was funny.

The commercial ended.

Lake went back to eating.

A few mornings later, Collette sat at the kitchen table filling out a school form. Lake leaned over her arm.

"What're you writin'?"

"Your birthday."

She wrote MAY 21, 1974 on the line marked DATE OF BIRTH.

Lake pointed at the next blank.

"What goes there?"

"If you'd quit leanin' on me, I might find out."

Lake straightened up. "Yes, Momma."

* * *

"Lake!"

He heard Minh before he saw him.

Minh was a boy about Lake's age. His parents had moved to America from Vietnam and settled nearby, bringing Minh and his brothers into a place far different from the country their family had left behind. Lake knew almost nothing about Vietnam. To him, Minh was simply Minh—his friend, another boy with a bicycle and an afternoon to fill.

Lake ran outside.

Minh stood beside his bicycle with his brothers.

"Momma!"

"What?"

"I'm goin' with Minh!"

Collette appeared behind the screen.

“Know where you’re at.”

“I will.”

“Be home before dark.”

“I will.”

“And don’t get in that ditch.”

“I won’t.”

Lake grabbed his bicycle.

Five minutes later all four boys were standing in the ditch.

Minh’s brothers talked to each other in Vietnamese.

Lake looked at Minh.

“What’re they sayin’?”

Minh shrugged.

“They say you ugly.”

Lake stared at them.

“They did not.”

Minh smiled.

“How you know?”

“Tell ’em I said they’re ugly.”

Minh rattled something off in Vietnamese.

His brothers laughed.

“What’d you tell ’em?”

“You say they handsome.”

“I did not!”

Minh took off running.

Lake chased him through the weeds.

“You better git back here!”

Later they sat on the bank throwing rocks into the water.

A pickup rattled past on the road above them, AM radio loud enough for a few seconds of music before the sound disappeared.

Lake pointed at himself.

“How you say Lake in your language?”

“Lake.”

“No. In your language.”

“Lake.”

“That ain’t no different.”

Minh laughed.

“How you say Minh?”

“Minh.”

“I already know that.”

“You not good teacher.”

“You ain’t either.”

Minh pointed toward the water and gave him the Vietnamese word.

Lake tried to repeat it.

Minh shook his head.

“No.”

“That’s what I said.”

“No.”

Lake tried again.

Minh laughed.

“You talk funny.”

“I talk funny? Listen to you.”

Minh shoved him.

Lake shoved him back.

A few minutes later Lake slowed his speech.

“You... wanna... go... over... there?”

Minh stared at him.

“What you doing?”

“What?”

“Why you talk like me?”

“I ain’t.”

“Yes.”

“I’m just makin’ it easier fer you to understand me.”

“I understand you.”

“Well, good.”

Minh smiled.

“You talk funny.”

“Shut up.”

They climbed out of the ditch with mud to their ankles.

Minh looked toward the road.

“My mama say we lucky be here.”

Lake wiped his shoe against the grass.

“Here in the ditch?”

Minh laughed.

“No. America.”

Lake looked around.

The road. The weeds. The trailers. The soybean field beyond them.

“What’s so lucky about it?”

Minh shrugged.

“My mama say.”

Lake considered that.

“My mama says I’m lucky when I don’t get a whoopin’.”

Minh laughed so hard he nearly slid back into the ditch.

* * *

Minh could draw.

Not stick people.

Real things.

Cars. Motorcycles. Animals.

Lake sat beside him one afternoon while Minh drew a car with flames rolling down the sides.

“How’d you do that?”

Minh shrugged.

“I draw.”

“Do me one.”

Minh started another.

A boy walked over.

“Can he draw me one?”

Lake answered before Minh could.

“Yeah.”

“How much?”

Lake looked at Minh.

Minh looked at Lake.

“A quarter.”

The boy dug into his pocket and handed Lake a quarter.

“Make mine a race car.”

Minh waited until he walked away.

“Why you take money?”

“’Cause he give it to me.”

“That my drawing.”

Lake looked at the quarter.

Then at Minh.

He dug into his own pocket, pulled out another quarter and handed it over.

“There.”

Minh looked at both coins.

“What?”

“Half.”

“You got quarter. I got quarter.”

“Yep.”

Another kid walked over.

“I want one.”

Lake pointed at him.

“Fifty cents.”

Minh turned.

“Fifty?”

Lake leaned closer.

“Don’t argue with me in front of the customer.”

“What customer?”

“Him.”

The boy looked at Minh.

“Can you draw a monster?”

“Sure can,” Lake said.

Minh looked at him.

“I never draw monster.”

Lake lowered his voice.

“You better learn.”

The boy came back the next day.

So did another.

Soon Minh sat drawing while Lake handled the talking.

“Motorcycle?”

“Fifty cents.”

“Dragon?”

“Fifty cents.”

“I never draw dragon.”

Lake leaned toward him.

“Well, you better learn. I done told him you could.”

“Why you say?”

“’Cause he’s got money.”

* * *

CHAPTER TWO

GROWING UP

One cold evening Collette turned on the kitchen faucet.

Cold water came out.

She waited.

Still cold.

“Alan!”

“What?”

“Ain’t got no hot water.”

Alan appeared and stared at the faucet as though it had personally offended him.

“Lake.”

“What?”

“Git the flashlight.”

Lake grabbed it and followed him.

The television was carrying another report about the hostages. A number appeared on the screen showing how many days they had been held.

Lake stopped.

“They still ain’t home?”

Alan opened the water-heater panel.

“Nope.”

“How come?”

“Lake, I don’t know. Hold this light.”

Lake aimed the beam.

Alan reached inside.

The wind blew underneath the trailer.

The little flame disappeared.

“Well, hell.”

Lake grinned.

“You said hell.”

“Hold the light.”

“You did.”

“Lake.”

“I’m holdin’ it.”

Alan relit the pilot.

Lake crouched closer.

“What makes the water hot?”

“The flame.”

“What if it goes out?”

“Water gets cold.”

“What do you do?”

“Light it ag’in.”

“What if it won’t light?”

“Figure out why.”

“What if you can’t figure it out?”

Alan looked at him.

“Then you keep foolin’ with the damn thing till you can.”

Lake smiled wider.

“You said damn.”

Alan pointed at the flashlight.

“Boy.”

“I’m holdin’ it.”

The television audience applauded in the other room.

Lake glanced toward it.

“Daddy?”

“What?”

“You think that Reagan man can git them people home?”

Alan turned the screwdriver.

“Don’t know.”

“You votin’ fer him?”

Alan looked at Lake.

“You ask more questions than anybody I ever seen.”

“That ain’t an answer.”

“Nope.”

“Who you votin’ fer?”

“Hold the light.”

Lake grinned.

“That means you ain’t tellin’.”

“That means hold the light.”

* * *

* * *

The grass behind the trailer had grown high around the septic hole.

It was not much of a septic tank. Alan had dug a big hole in the ground, and a thin sheet of metal lay across the top of the dirty water below.

Grass had grown around the edges and over parts of the metal until it was hard to tell where solid ground ended.

Collette came around the side of the trailer carrying a basket against her hip.

Lake was in the yard when he heard the metal buckle.

WHUMP.

The basket hit the grass.

Then Collette disappeared.

“Momma!”

Lake ran toward the hole.

“Alan!” Collette screamed.

Alan came around the trailer at a run.

Collette had broken through the thin metal and dropped into the septic water. The hole was deep enough to swallow most of her, but not deep enough to pull her completely under.

She grabbed at the edge.

“Get me outta here!”

Alan dropped to his knees and reached for her.

“Gimme your hand.”

“What do you think I’m tryin’ to do?”

Lake crouched beside him.

“Daddy, is she okay?”

“She’s okay. Back up so you don’t fall in too.”

Alan caught Collette by both arms and pulled while she kicked against the side of the hole.

She slid onto the grass soaking wet.

For a moment nobody said anything.

Lake stared at her.

Collette pushed wet hair away from her face.

“Don’t.”

Lake pressed his lips together.

Alan stood and took one step toward her.

Then he stopped.

Collette narrowed her eyes.

“Why’d you stop?”

Alan rubbed his nose.

“Just makin’ sure you’re all right.”

“From over there?”

Lake snorted.

Collette turned toward him.

“You laugh and I’ll throw you in it.”

Lake covered his mouth with both hands.

Alan looked away, but his shoulders moved.

“You too, Alan.”

“I ain’t said nothin’.”

“You don’t have to.”

Collette started toward the trailer.

Lake took a cautious breath through his nose and immediately regretted it.

“Momma.”

She stopped.

“What?”

Lake pinched his nose.

“You stink.”

Collette pointed toward the septic hole.

Lake ran.

Alan finally laughed.

“You better run, boy.”

Mrs. Parker placed the blue reading book on the desk.

Lake stared at the word.

“I don’t know.”

“Don’t guess. Sound it out.”

He tried.

One sound.

Then another.

The pieces slowly came together.

Lake looked up.

“I read it.”

Mrs. Parker smiled.

“Yes, you did.”

He looked back down.

He tried the next word.

That afternoon he carried Dilly Dilly home.

Alan sat at the kitchen table.

“Daddy, listen.”

“To what?”

“I can read.”

Alan leaned back.

“Well, read.”

Lake opened the book and put his finger beneath the first word.

He worked his way across the page.

When he finished, he looked up.

Alan nodded.

“Pretty good.”

“I messed up one.”

“Still pretty good.”

A few evenings later Lake came into the kitchen and found Alan sitting at the same table.

An envelope lay open beside him.

A form was spread out in front of him.

Alan turned it over.

Then back again.

Lake climbed into the chair beside him.

“What’s that?”

“Paper.”

“I know it’s paper.”

“Then why’d you ask?”

Lake pulled it closer.

He sounded out the first word.

“Name.”

He pointed.

“That says name.”

Alan looked at the blank line.

“Write yours.”

Alan picked up the pencil.

He made a C.

Stopped.

Lake watched him.

“Keep goin’.”

Alan stared at the letter.

“That C looks like hell.”

From the stove Collette turned around.

“Alan!”

“What?”

“You know better.”

Lake smiled.

“You said hell.”

“Don’t you start.”

Lake took the pencil.

“I’ll help ya.”

Alan slid the paper toward him.

Lake worked through it one word at a time.

Some he knew.

Some he didn’t.

When he got stuck, Collette helped from the kitchen.

When they finished, Alan picked up the form.

“That everything?”

“Reckon.”

Alan folded it.

“Appreciate it.”

Lake opened his reading book.

“You wanna try this’un?”

Alan looked at the page.

Then at his son.

“You ain’t tired?”

“Nope.”

Alan pulled his chair closer.

“All right. Show me.”

Lake put his finger under the first word.

This time he sounded it out slowly enough for both of them.

* * *

Another evening Collette sat at the table with a grocery list.

Alan pushed a pencil toward her.

“Write nails on there.”

Lake looked up from Dilly Dilly.

“Why don’t you write it?”

Alan looked at him.

“Boy.”

“I’m just askin’.”

Collette wrote NAILS on the paper.

Lake pointed at the word.

“You can read it, Momma?”

“Yes.”

“You went to school longer than Daddy?”

Collette set the pencil down.

“Longer. Didn’t make it to high school.”

Lake looked at Alan.

“How far’d you go?”

Alan rubbed one thumb across the edge of the table.

“Not far.”

“Why?”

“Cotton wasn’t gonna pick itself.”

Lake waited.

Alan leaned back.

“Granddaddy needed help in the fields. So I went to the fields.”

“How old were you?”

Alan looked toward Collette.

“Young.”

Lake opened the blue reader again.

“I ain’t quittin’ learnin’.”

Alan looked at the book.

“Then don’t.”

Lake put his finger beneath the next line and started reading aloud.

* * *

The potbelly stove popped in the living room.

Lake lay beneath a blanket near it while the television played.

Punkin grabbed the other end.

“Give it back.”

“I’m cold.”

“Git your own.”

“This is mine.”

“No it ain’t.”

She pulled.

Lake pulled harder.

“Daddy!”

Alan looked away from the television.

“What?”

“Punkin’s takin’ my blanket.”

“No I ain’t!”

Alan turned back toward the television.

“Figure it out.”

Lake yanked.

Punkin let go.

Lake rolled backward.

She burst out laughing.

“You did that on purpose!”

“Did not.”

The television picture jumped.

Alan got up and slapped the side.
The picture straightened.
Lake watched him.
“How’d you know to do that?”
“Years of trainin’.”
The picture rolled again.
Lake jumped up and slapped it.
Collette turned from the kitchen.
“Don’t hit that television!”
“Daddy did!”
“Your daddy paid for it.”
Lake sat back down.
Alan smiled without looking at him.
A news bulletin interrupted the program.
The hostages were coming home.
Lake sat up.
“Daddy. Them people.”
Alan turned the volume up.
The room got quiet.
Men and women stepped from an airplane on the screen. Families waved. People hugged.
Punkin crawled closer to the television.
“Where they been?”
“Iran,” Lake said.
She looked at him.
“Where’s that?”
“Long ways.”
Alan glanced at him.
Lake smiled.
“Farther than St. Louis.”
Alan nodded.
“That’s right.”

* * *

Sunday morning the preacher gripped the pulpit.

Jesus was coming back.

The saved would be taken.

The lost would remain.

Lake sat beside Collette.

“Momma.”

“Shh.”

“How old you gotta be?”

“For what?”

“Before God sends you to hell?”

Collette looked down at him.

“Listen to the preacher. We’ll talk later.”

Lake sat back.

The preacher spoke about wars and rumors of wars. About nations. About the end times.

Lake thought about Iran.

About presidents.

About people disappearing.

About the little mint-green trailer sitting exactly where they had left it.

That night he lay on his pallet in the little room Alan had built.

He stared into the darkness.

He folded his hands.

“Jesus, forgive me fer everything I done wrong.”

He stopped.

“And everything I forgot.”

Silence.

“Amen.”

His eyes opened.

“An’ that too.”

He rolled over.

A few seconds passed.

Lake rolled onto his back again.

“And if I thought somethin’ bad but didn’t do it, forgive me fer that too.”

From the other side of the thin wall came Punkin’s voice.

“Shut up.”

“I’m prayin’.”

“You’re keepin’ me awake.”

“What if Jesus comes back tonight?”

Punkin was quiet.

Lake waited.

“Punkin?”

“Now you got me scared.”

“Sorry.”

Another silence.

“Lake?”

“What?”

“You think Momma and Daddy are ready?”

“I reckon.”

“What about us?”

Lake stared at the ceiling.

“I don’t know.”

Neither child said anything else.

Outside, the wind moved through the bare trees.

A car passed on the highway somewhere beyond the field.

The trailer creaked.

Lake pulled the blanket to his chin.

Three-quarters of the house outside was green.

In the dark, none of it showed.

CHAPTER THREE

MAY 25, 1986

The wind hit the trailer hard enough to make the metal skin pop.

Lake looked up.

POP.

A second crack snapped through the ceiling above him.

The thin walls trembled.

Rain exploded against the metal roof.

Not drops anymore. A roar.

It sounded like somebody standing on top of the trailer throwing handfuls of rocks as hard as they could.

Lake slid closer to Punkin.

“Daddy?”

Alan was already at the window.

The trailer shifted beneath Lake’s feet.

Not much.

Enough.

Collette grabbed the edge of the table.

Something slammed into the roof.

Lake ducked and covered his head.

Another impact followed.

“What is that?”

Nobody answered him.

The wind struck broadside.

The wall bowed with a metallic groan and popped back.

Punkin clamped both hands over her ears.

“Make it stop!”

Alan pulled the curtain aside.

Outside had disappeared into gray water and whipping trees.

Lake watched Daddy's face.

Alan did not scare easy.

His face scared Lake more than the wind did.

Another gust lifted something beneath the trailer with a hard THUMP.

The floor jumped.

Collette looked at Alan.

"Alan."

He kept staring through the glass.

The trailer creaked from one end to the other.

A cabinet door swung open by itself.

A plate slid off the counter and shattered.

Punkin screamed.

Lake grabbed her arm.

"Daddy, is it gonna turn us over?"

Alan spun from the window.

"We ain't stayin' in this damn thing."

Collette stared at him.

"Alan, look outside!"

"I am lookin'."

The roof gave another violent crack.

Lake looked up and imagined the whole sheet of metal peeling away.

Alan pointed toward the door.

"Git your shoes on. Now."

Lake shoved his feet into them without socks and without tying them.

His fingers would not work right.

Punkin was crying.

Collette grabbed her around the shoulders.

“Stay with me.”

Alan reached for the door.

“When I open this, we run straight to the car. Nobody stops. Nobody turns around. You hear me?”

Lake nodded.

“I said, you hear me?”

“Yes, sir.”

Alan opened the door.

The wind ripped it out of his hand and slammed it against the side of the trailer.

Rain blew sideways through the doorway and across the floor.

For half a second nobody moved.

Then the trailer popped again behind them.

“GO!” Alan yelled.

Lake ran.

The rain hit his face so hard he could barely keep his eyes open.

Wind shoved him sideways.

One untied shoe nearly came off in the mud.

He heard Punkin crying behind him and Alan yelling ahead of him.

The Buick looked impossibly far away even though it was only across the yard.

Lake stumbled, caught himself with one hand and kept running.

Alan yanked open the door of the 1978 Buick LeSabre.

“Get in!”

Collette pushed Punkin across the seat.

Lake dove in after her.

Alan dropped behind the wheel and fought the door shut.

The Buick rocked in the wind.

Punkin was sobbing now.

Lake stared through the windshield.

The wipers moved as fast as they could and still lost.

Water swallowed the road between every pass.

Alan leaned over the steering wheel.

“Can you see?” Collette asked.

“Enough.”

“Where are we going?”

“Somewhere that ain’t got wheels under it.”

The Buick crawled forward.

Lake twisted around in the seat and looked through the rear window.

For a moment he could still see the little trailer.

Then a sheet of rain erased it.

His stomach dropped.

“Daddy?”

Alan did not look back.

“What?”

“Is our house gonna blow away?”

Alan gripped the wheel with both hands.

He did not answer right away.

That silence told Lake more than an answer would have.

“Daddy?”

“I don’t know, son.”

Lake turned back toward the rear window.

There was nothing there but rain.

They passed another mobile home.

A car pulled out behind them.

Then another.

Farther down the road, porch lights glowed through the storm.

Cars and pickups crowded the yard around a house that sat solid on the ground.

Alan pulled in behind them.

People were running from vehicles toward the porch.

“Come on.”

They ran again.

Inside, wet families filled every room.

Children sat on the floor. Women wrapped towels around shaking shoulders. Men stood near the windows until somebody shouted at them to get away from the glass.

Another family from the trailer park burst through the door.

Then another.

Lake sat on the floor beside Punkin.

The house shook when the wind hit.

But it did not pop.

It did not lift beneath them.

Punkin pressed against his side.

“You think our house is still there?”

Lake looked across the crowded room at Alan.

Daddy stood near the doorway, soaked through, water dripping from his clothes onto the floor.

“Daddy?”

Alan looked at him.

“What?”

Lake’s voice came out smaller than he wanted.

“Is it still there?”

Alan wiped rain from his face.

“We’ll find out when this is over.”

Lake pulled his knees against his chest.

Outside, the wind screamed against a house without wheels.

CHAPTER FOUR

WORK

Lake was fourteen the first summer he walked into a cornfield before the heat had fully climbed over it.

Rows of corn stretched farther than he could see. Dew soaked his jeans before the morning was half gone.

A man at the end of the row pointed toward the tassels.

“Pull the wrong ones and you’ll know it.”

Lake looked down the row. “How?”

“Somebody’ll holler at you.”

Lake grinned. “Then I reckon I’ll learn fast.”

By noon his shoulders burned. By afternoon his hands were scratched and sticky. The next morning he was back.

* * *

Hay season brought a different kind of hurt.

Lake stood on a wagon while square bales came up one after another.

“Stack ’em tight,” the farmer called.

Lake caught another bale against his chest and shoved it into place.

Dust stuck to the sweat on his face. His forearms itched. When the wagon was full, he climbed down, drank from a jug, and climbed onto the next one.

* * *

Not long after that, Alan came home from the factory with broken pallets on a little trailer behind the Buick.

Lake stepped into the yard. “What’re them for?”

Alan dropped the trailer tongue. “Gonna see if I can fix ’em.”

“For who?”

“Factory. They’re throwin’ ’em away. If I can make ’em usable, they’ll buy ’em back cheaper than new ones.”

Lake looked at the pile of split boards and bent nails.

“Need help?”

Alan handed him a hammer.

“Thought you’d never ask.”

The two of them pulled nails, replaced boards and squared crooked pallets in the yard. What began as a few broken pallets became more. Then more again.

Lake learned which boards could be saved before Alan had to tell him.

* * *

By sixteen, Lake was pushing carts across the Walmart parking lot beneath the lights after school.

A textbook waited in the car.

His supervisor pointed toward another line of carts rolling loose across the pavement.

“Farmer.”

Lake looked over.

“Thought you were goin’ home.”

“I am.”

“When?”

Lake caught the first cart. “Soon as these quit multiplyin’.”

* * *

On other days he went from school to a farm-machinery shop.

Grease worked into the lines of his hands while he tore worn pieces apart, cleaned them, replaced what could not be saved and put them back together.

The boss watched him turn a part over in his hands.

“You ever worked on one of these before?”

“No.”

“Then how you know where that goes?”

Lake pointed at the wear mark.

“Only place it makes sense.”

The man looked at him for a moment, then nodded toward the machine.

“Put it back together.”

* * *

School fit wherever there was room.

Lake sat at the kitchen table late one night with a worksheet spread beside a plate gone cold.

Collette stopped behind him. “You gotta work tomorrow?”

“After school.”

“Walmart?”

“Farm shop first. Pallets after that if Daddy’s got a load.”

She looked at the paper beneath his hand.

“And this?”

Lake rubbed his eyes and picked up the pencil.

“Gotta do that too.”

* * *

The rusty light-blue Volkswagen Beetle rattled into the school parking lot.

Lake worked the five-speed shifter and eased it into a space.

A boy leaning against another car looked over.

“That thing still runnin’?”

Lake shut it off.

“Got me here.”

“Barely.”

Lake grabbed his books.

“Barely counts.”

The boy looked at the rust along the fender.

“In 1990 you coulda bought somethin’ prettier.”

Lake looked back at the Beetle.

“Pretty don’t get me to work.”

* * *

CHAPTER FIVE

HIS NAME ON THE PAPER

The next year, a 1981 Pontiac Firebird sat on a lot with $2,995 written across the windshield.

Lake walked around it once.

Then again.

The salesman watched him.

“You like it?”

Lake stopped at the driver’s door.

“Yeah.”

“You got somebody to co-sign?”

“No.”

The salesman looked at him.

“How old are you?”

“Seventeen.”

“You work?”

“Three jobs.”

“Three?”

“Walmart. I rebuild farm machinery. Rebuild pallets too.”

“And school?”

“Still there.”

The salesman stared at him for a second.

“Come inside.”

* * *

Lake sat across from the lender with his pay information spread across the desk.

The man tapped one of the papers.

“Walmart.”

He tapped another.

“Farm machinery.”

Then another.

“Pallets.”

Lake nodded.

“Yes, sir.”

“No co-signer?”

“No, sir.”

“Nobody else’s name is going on this loan?”

“No, sir.”

The man leaned back.

“You understand you make the payment whether you have a good week or a bad week?”

“Yes, sir.”

“And you’re still in high school.”

“Tryin’ to finish.”

The man looked over the papers again.

Then he picked up his pen.

“All right.”

Lake looked at him.

“All right what?”

“Sign here.”

Lake took the pen.

* * *

The Firebird rolled into the school parking lot.

The same boy who had laughed at the Beetle looked up.

“Where’s the bug?”

Lake shut off the Pontiac and stepped out.

“Moved up.”

“Your daddy buy that?”

Lake closed the door.

“Nope.”

“Who did?”
Lake tucked his books under his arm.
“You’re lookin’ at him.”
He walked toward the school.

* * *

Alan walked around the Firebird slowly.
“What?” Lake asked.
“Nothin’.”
“You don’t like it?”
“I didn’t say that.”
Alan crouched and looked underneath.
“What’re you doin’?”
“Lookin’.”
“For what?”
“Trouble.”
Lake folded his arms.
“You always look fer trouble.”
Alan stood.
“That’s why I find it before you do.”
He looked over the car once more.
“Nice car.”
Lake looked up.
“What?”
“I said it’s a nice car.”
Lake smiled.
“Yeah.”

* * *

* * *

By senior year, the days seemed to run together: school, Walmart, farm machinery, pallets, sleep, then school again.

A teacher stopped Lake as he gathered his books.

"You planning to graduate, Farmer?"

Lake looked at her. "That's the plan."

"Then you need to be here enough to finish."

He tucked the book under his arm.

"I'll finish."

* * *

CHAPTER SIX

GRADUATION DAY

Lake adjusted the collar of his graduation gown.

Around him, chairs scraped and voices bounced through the room while the class waited to walk out.

A boy beside him looked over. “You nervous?”

“No.”

“You look nervous.”

Lake pulled at the collar again. “I’m hot.”

When his name was called, Lake crossed the stage and took the diploma.

Alan and Collette were somewhere beyond the lights.

Lake held the paper in one hand and walked off the stage.

For once there was no clock to punch before he could finish what he had started.

CHAPTER SEVEN

ELLEN

The Taco John's dining room was nearly empty.

Lake sat in his church clothes across from Lacey, half listening while she talked. Another girl sat with them.

Ellen.

Lake looked at her.

She looked away.

A few seconds later, he looked again.

She was looking at him.

Lake smiled.

Ellen smiled back.

Lacey kept talking.

Lake nodded as though he had heard any of it.

Ellen lowered her eyes toward her food.

Lake took a drink.

Then looked at her again.

Ellen caught him.

"What?"

"Nothin'."

"You keep lookin' at me."

"You keep lookin' at me."

"I do not."

Lake grinned.

"Okay."

Ellen tried not to smile.

Lacey looked between them.

"What?"

“Nothin’,” they said together.

Lake looked at her again.

“When’s your birthday?”

Ellen raised an eyebrow. “May twenty-eighth.”

“What year?”

“1978. Why?”

“Mine’s May twenty-first, 1974.”

Ellen smiled. “So you’re old.”

Lake grinned. “Seven days ain’t that much.”

“And four years.”

“I was leavin’ that part out.”

* * *

Lake stood on Dale and Mary’s porch and wiped his palms against his jeans.

The door opened.

Dale looked at him.

“Yeah?”

“Ellen here?”

“Maybe.”

Lake swallowed.

“I was wonderin’ if I could take her out.”

Dale stared at him for another second.

Then he turned his head.

“Ellen!”

“What?”

“You got somebody out here.”

Ellen appeared behind him.

She looked at Lake.

“What’re you doing here?”

Lake looked at Dale.

Then back at Ellen.

“Apparently regrettin’ some decisions.”

Dale almost smiled.

Ellen stepped onto the porch.

“What do you want?”

“You wanna go out with me?”

She folded her arms.

“That depends.”

“On what?”

“Where?”

Lake hadn’t thought that far ahead.

“I don’t know.”

Ellen laughed.

“You came all the way over here and asked my daddy if you could take me out and you don’t even know where?”

“I was workin’ on one problem at a time.”

“Which problem am I?”

Lake grinned.

“The current one.”

She shook her head.

“Yes.”

“Yes what?”

“Yes, I’ll go out with you.”

Lake nodded.

“All right.”

He turned toward the steps.

Ellen stared at him.

“That’s it?”

He turned around.

“What?”

“You’re leaving?”

“I got what I came for.”

She laughed.

“You are weird.”

“You said yes.”

“I might change my mind.”

Lake came back up one step.

“When you wanna go?”

* * *

Music lived in Dale and Mary’s house.

A guitar leaned in one corner. A banjo case sat near a chair. Somebody was always humming, tuning, picking or singing.

Lake sat beside Ellen with a guitar across his lap.

“Don’t laugh.”

“I’m not gonna laugh.”

“You already look like you’re gonna laugh.”

“I’m smiling.”

“There’s a difference?”

“Sing.”

Lake strummed the opening chords to “Forever and Ever, Amen.”

A few lines in, Ellen joined him.

Lake stopped playing.

“What?”

Her voice was lower than he expected. Warm. Soulful.

“What?” she asked.

“You can sing.”

“So can you.”

“No. I mean you can sing.”

Ellen laughed.

“My family plays music.”

“You never told me that.”

“You never asked.”

Lake started playing again.

“Start over.”

“Why?”
“Because now I gotta sound better.”
“You ain’t gonna.”
“See, now that’s just hateful.”
She leaned against him.
“Play.”
He did.
Later Dale put a banjo in Lake’s hands.
Lake stared at the strings.
“How many fingers am I supposed to have?”
“The same number you got.”
“That ain’t enough.”
Dale showed him a roll.
Lake tried it.
The notes stumbled over one another.
Ellen covered her ears.
“That sounds terrible.”
Lake stopped.
“You wanna do it?”
“No.”
“Then hush.”
He tried again.

* * *

Three months moved through porch visits, church clothes, guitars, cheap meals and long conversations.

Lake sat beside Ellen one evening.
“You ever think about gittin’ married?”
She looked at him.
“Sometimes.”
“To who?”
She laughed.
“I don’t know.”

“Well, figure it out.”

“Why?”

“Because I’m askin’.”

Her smile disappeared.

“You’re serious?”

“Yeah.”

“Lake.”

“What?”

“We haven’t known each other that long.”

“I know you.”

“You think you do.”

“I know enough.”

“What’s enough?”

He looked at her.

“Enough to know I don’t wanna go home without you.”

Ellen stared at him.

“That’s your proposal?”

“I can do it again.”

“No.”

“No?”

“No, don’t do it again.”

Lake’s face fell.

Ellen laughed.

“I mean yes.”

He stared.

“Yes?”

“Yes.”

He kissed her before she could change the wording.

* * *

June 24, 1995.

A horse shifted beneath Lake.

He tightened the reins.

“Quit movin’.”

Someone behind him laughed.

Lake turned.

“What?”

“You nervous?”

“No.”

The horse moved again.

Lake looked down.

“I think he is.”

Then Ellen appeared.

Lake stopped talking.

She rode toward him.

For a moment the people, horses and voices around them disappeared behind Lake’s stare.

Ellen smiled.

“What?”

“Nothin’.”

“You look scared.”

“I ain’t scared.”

“You look scared.”

“I’m on a horse gettin’ married. I’m allowed to look however I want.”

She laughed.

Alan and Collette stood among the family. Dale and Mary were nearby.

The ceremony began.

Later somebody handed Lake the guitar.

Ellen looked at him.

“You ain’t.”

“I am.”

“Here?”

“Yep.”

He found the chord.

“Don’t laugh.”
“I married you. I’m allowed.”
Lake began “Forever and Ever, Amen.”
Ellen’s smile softened.
By the end, other voices had joined his.
Lake looked at his wife.
The horse shifted again.
“Would you quit?”
Ellen laughed.

* * *

The twelve-by-sixty trailer sat on Dale and Mary’s property.

CHAPTER EIGHT

BROOKE AND PATTY

Lake stood beside Ellen at the bottom of the pallet steps.

She looked at the trailer.

Then at him.

“This is it?”

“This is it.”

She looked at the pallets.

“Those are our steps?”

“Temporarily.”

“How temporarily?”

Lake looked at them.

“Don’t know.”

Ellen climbed onto the first pallet.

It shifted.

She grabbed Lake.

“Lake!”

“I got you.”

“You said these were steps!”

“They are.”

“They moved!”

“They’re adjustable.”

She stared at him.

He grinned.

“You married me.”

“That may have been my first mistake.”

“First?”

“I’m leavin’ room.”

Inside, the kitchen was tiny. The living room held a hideaway sofa. One bathroom served the

whole place. The bedroom on the south end had the only window air conditioner.

By afternoon, Missouri heat pressed against the aluminum walls.

Ellen picked up a candle from a shelf.

It leaned sideways.

“Lake.”

“What?”

“My candle melted.”

“It ain’t melted.”

“It’s bent.”

“Still a candle.”

She held it up.

“It looks tired.”

“So am I.”

* * *

Lake and Dale stood over the place where the septic tank was supposed to go.

Lake held a shovel.

Dale held another.

“Think it’ll work?” Lake asked.

“It better.”

“What happens if it doesn’t?”

Dale looked at him.

“I guess you dig it back up.”

Lake stared at the ground.

“You notice how everything ends with me diggin’?”

“Your house.”

Lake drove the shovel into the dirt.

They dug.

And dug.

The bleeder line stretched away from the trailer.

When the hole was finally ready, a tractor boom lowered the tank.

Lake watched it settle.

Dale looked over.

“You wanted to be married.”

Lake wiped sweat from his face.

“I thought there’d be more kissin’.”

Dale laughed.

“Dig.”

* * *

One evening Ellen slid a Red Baron frozen pizza into the oven.

Lake came in later and stopped.

“You smell that?”

Ellen’s eyes widened.

“The pizza.”

She opened the oven.

Smoke rolled out.

Lake stepped back.

“Good Lord.”

“Shut up.”

She pulled out something black around the edges and dark brown everywhere else.

Lake stared at it.

“You killed it.”

“I forgot.”

“It’s been cremated.”

Ellen looked at him.

Lake looked at her.

Neither spoke.

Then Ellen started laughing.

Lake tried to hold it.

He couldn't.

She cut away the worst parts.

They sat together and ate what survived.

Lake chewed.

"Not bad."

"You're lying."

"Little crunchy."

"It's charcoal."

He took another bite.

"We paid for it."

Ellen laughed again.

March 22, 1996.

Lake stood beside Ellen and looked down at Brooke.

The baby's fingers opened and closed.

Lake touched one.

Her hand closed around it.

He froze.

Ellen watched him.

"What?"

"Nothin'."

"You're crying."

"No I ain't."

"You are."

Lake wiped his face.

"Hospital's dry."

"Sure."

He looked down again.

"Hey, Brooke."

The baby held on.

Lake didn't move his finger.

* * *

June 12, 1997.

Lake held Patty while Brooke stood beside Ellen.

Brooke reached toward the blanket.

“Baby.”

“Yep,” Lake said. “That’s your sister.”

Brooke poked at Patty.

“Easy.”

Brooke poked again.

“Brooke.”

She looked up at him.

“What?”

Lake laughed.

Ellen shook her head.

“You got two of ’em now.”

Lake looked from one daughter to the other.

“What am I supposed to do with two girls?”

“Learn.”

“That’s everybody’s answer.”

At night the hideaway sofa became a family bed when the girls wouldn’t settle.

Lake lay on one edge.

Ellen lay on the other.

Brooke and Patty occupied most of the middle despite being the smallest people in the house.

Lake whispered, “How does somebody this little take up this much room?”

Ellen’s eyes stayed closed.

“Go to sleep.”

Patty kicked him.

Lake moved farther toward the edge.

“I’m about to sleep on the floor.”

“You’ll be back.”

“Why?”
“Because they’ll wake up.”
Lake looked at the two little faces.
“Yeah.”
He stayed.

CHAPTER NINE

KIDS GROWIN' UP

The kitchen table became a school desk.

Ellen sat between Brooke and Patty with books, pencils and worksheets spread across the table.

"Patty, sit down."

"I am sitting down."

"You are halfway out of the chair."

"That still counts."

Brooke covered her mouth and giggled.

"Don't encourage her," Ellen said.

Patty dropped back into the chair. "How many more?"

"All of them."

"That's too many."

Brooke laughed again.

"Brooke."

"I'm sorry, Mom."

She wasn't.

* * *

The girls could not have been more different.

Brooke was fair-skinned and blonde, tenderhearted enough to cry over almost anything. She loved mud, fishing and anything that let her stay outside until Ellen called her in.

Patty had curly brown hair, an olive complexion and an opinion about nearly

everything. Once she planted her feet, moving her took more than logic.

The family's rescued greyhound, Queenie, discovered that before anyone else.

Patty took off across the yard after her.

"I can catch her!"

"No, you can't," Brooke yelled.

Queenie stretched into a run.

Patty lasted half the yard.

"Come back here!"

Queenie made a wide circle, came racing back and stopped beside Patty as though she had never left.

Patty bent over, hands on her knees.

"I almost had you."

Queenie licked her across the face.

Brooke doubled over laughing.

* * *

Brooke came through the door one afternoon covered in mud.

Ellen stared at her.

Brooke's eyes filled immediately.

"I'm sorry."

Ellen's face softened.

"Come here."

"I didn't mean to."

"I know. You're not in trouble."

Brooke sniffed.

"Then why're you looking at me like that?"

"Because you look like you rolled with a hog."

Brooke laughed through the tears while Ellen cleaned her up.

* * *

Fishing with Lake was no safer for Brooke's heart.

The line jerked.

"Daddy!"

"Pull!"

Brooke reeled until a fish broke the surface.

"I got one!"

Lake helped bring it in.

Brooke's smile disappeared when she saw the hook.

"Does that hurt him?"

"He'll be all right."

"Take it out."

"I am."

"Daddy, hurry."

By the time Lake freed the hook, Brooke was crying.

"Put him back."

Lake lowered the fish into the water. It disappeared with one flick of its tail.

Brooke wiped her face.

A moment later she picked up the pole.

"I wanna catch another one."

Lake looked at her.

"What?"

He smiled. "Nothin'."

* * *

Patty found the fiddle.

At first, the notes scratched through the room hard enough to make Lake wince.

Patty stopped.

“You made a face.”

“I did not.”

“You did.”

“I had an itch.”

“On your whole face?”

From her chair, Nana Mary laughed.

“Play it again,” Mary said.

Patty lifted the fiddle.

The next attempt was better.

Mary tapped her foot.

“Again.”

Patty played it again.

And again.

Before long, the fiddle belonged in the sound of the family as naturally as Brooke’s laughter.

* * *

Both girls stayed close to Nana.

Brooke would curl against Mary as though she could still make herself little enough to fit there forever.

Patty talked. Mary listened. When Patty had an opinion, Mary let her finish it before offering one of her own.

One afternoon Mary had both girls beside her.

“You two gonna stay little forever?”

“No,” Patty said. “I wanna grow up.”

Brooke leaned closer to Nana.

“I might stay little.”

“You might?”

“I don’t wanna grow up.”

Mary kissed the top of her head.

“I wish you could.”

Patty looked over.

Mary smiled at both of them.

“You’ve both got plenty of time.”

For once, Patty didn’t argue.

Queenie lay nearby. Patty’s fiddle rested in its case. Brooke’s muddy shoes waited by the door.

Mary held the girls close.

And the afternoon went on.

CHAPTER TEN

THE DEATH OF NANA

The winter would not let go.

Cold pressed against the windows. The ground stayed hard, the sky stayed gray, and every trip outside began with somebody pulling a coat tighter around themselves.

Ellen stood at the kitchen counter with the telephone against her ear.

Lake came through the door and stopped when he saw her face.

“What happened?”

Ellen did not answer him at first.

“Ellen?”

She lowered the phone.

“Mom has cancer.”

Lake set his keys down.

“What kind?”

Ellen swallowed.

“Pancreatic.”

* * *

Mary had always been there.

At Dale and Mary’s house, somebody was usually talking, somebody was eating, and music was never far away. A guitar might be leaning against a wall. A banjo case might be under a chair. Mary moved through the middle of it all as though keeping a family together was simply another thing that needed doing.

Now medicine bottles stood where coffee cups used to sit.

Brooke and Patty came through the door more quietly than they once had.

Mary looked toward them.

“Why are y’all creeping around?”

Brooke shrugged.

“We ain’t.”

“Yes, you are. Come here.”

The girls went to her. Mary pulled them close.

“I’m still Nana.”

Patty leaned against her.

“I know.”

Ellen stood a few feet away with her arms folded tightly across herself.

Mary looked past the girls at her daughter.

“You too.”

Ellen shook her head.

“Mama.”

“Get over here.”

Ellen crossed the room. Mary reached for her hand.

Lake turned toward the window. Bare branches moved in the winter wind.

* * *

The weeks became appointments, telephone calls and waiting rooms.

Lake sat beside Ellen while she stared at a hospital vending machine without putting money into it.

“You want something?” he asked.

“No.”

“You been sittin’ here ten minutes.”

“I know.”

He waited.

Ellen rubbed both hands over her face.

“I can’t lose her.”

Lake looked down the hallway toward Mary’s room.

“I know.”

“No, you don’t.”

He looked back at Ellen.

“No. I don’t.”

She leaned against him. Lake put his arm around her and said nothing else.

* * *

FEBRUARY 2009.

The cold was still there when the telephone rang.

Ellen answered it.

Lake looked up from the table.

“Hello?”

Ellen went still.

Lake stood.

“What is it?”

The telephone slipped lower in her hand.

“Mom’s gone.”

Lake crossed the kitchen before she could fall apart alone.

Ellen folded against him. The sound that came out of her did not sound like crying at first.

Brooke appeared in the hallway. Patty came behind her.

Neither girl asked what had happened.

Brooke covered her mouth. Patty stared at her mother.

Lake held Ellen while the telephone hung from her hand.

* * *

At the funeral home, people kept coming.

They hugged Dale. They hugged Ellen. They hugged the girls. They told stories about Mary. They said how much she had meant to them.

Lake watched Ellen thank each person.

Then the room emptied.

Ellen stood in front of Mary's casket after everyone else had moved toward the door.

Lake waited several steps behind her.

Brooke took Patty's hand.

Ellen touched the edge of the casket.

"I don't know how to do this without you, Mama."

Lake lowered his eyes.

* * *

After Mary, the house changed.

Some evenings Ellen sat at the kitchen table long after everybody else had finished eating. A drink stood beside her.

Lake stopped in the doorway one night.

"You comin' to bed?"

"In a minute."

He looked at the glass.

"You said that an hour ago."

Ellen looked away.

"I'm fine."

Lake pulled out the chair across from her.

“I didn’t ask if you were fine.”

Her eyes filled.

“Then don’t ask.”

Lake stayed in the chair.

The girls learned when to talk to their mother and when to give her room.

Brooke found Ellen asleep on the couch one afternoon and pulled a blanket over her.

Patty stood in the doorway.

“Is Mom okay?”

Brooke looked toward the kitchen, where an empty glass sat beside the sink.

“I don’t know.”

Lake heard them from the hallway.

He looked at Ellen asleep beneath the blanket and then at his daughters.

“She misses Nana.”

Patty looked at him.

“We all do.”

“I know.”

Ellen began gaining weight. Clothes disappeared into the back of the closet and larger ones replaced them. The drinks came more often. Some days she laughed with the girls and sounded like herself. Other days Mary’s absence seemed to sit in the room with her.

Lake tried jokes. He tried silence. He tried sitting beside her. He tried giving her space.

Nothing brought Mary back.

* * *

CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE CAMPER YEARS

After Mary died, the days kept coming.

Lake worked. Ellen got up. The girls grew. Bills arrived. Supper had to be made. Morning came again.

Nobody talked about surviving.

They just did it.

* * *

Three months after Mary died, in May 2009, Dale married Sue.

One evening Dale started a story.

“Mary used to—”

He stopped.

Sue looked at him. “Why’d you stop?”

Dale shifted in his chair.

Sue shook her head.

“She was your wife. You loved her. You ain’t gotta stop saying her name because I’m sitting here.”

Dale looked at her for a moment.

Then he finished the story.

Sue listened.

She never treated Mary’s memory like competition. Her name stayed in the room. Her pictures stayed where they belonged. Her stories could still be told.

Sue simply found her own place.

* * *

Ellen noticed it too.

One afternoon she looked at Sue and said, “I admire you.”

Sue laughed. “What’d I do?”

“A lot more than you think.”

Ellen looked toward Dale.

“You’ve been good for Daddy.”

“I love him.”

Ellen nodded. “And you’ve been good for me too.”

Sue hugged her.

Nobody could give Ellen her mother back.

Ellen didn’t expect anyone to.

Mary would always be Mom.

But somewhere along the way, without forcing it or asking for it, Sue had become someone Ellen could lean on too.

A mother figure.

Someone she admired.

For Dale, Sue had been a godsend.

For Ellen, she became something Ellen hadn’t expected to find again.

And for a family that had spent years being knocked around by grief, Sue brought something they desperately needed.

Peace.

* * *

Several years later Lake looked at Ellen.

“You know what we need?”

“Money?”

“A camper.”

“With what money?”

“We’ll figure it out.”

“And what are we gonna do with a camper?”

“Camp.”

“I gathered that.”

Lake grinned.

“No work. No running. No fixing things. Just weekends.”

Ellen narrowed her eyes. “It better have air conditioning.”

* * *

At the campground, Brooke found friends and the river.

Patty found the old-timers.

A guitar started. Then a banjo.

Patty lifted her fiddle.

Before long, “Boil Them Cabbage Down” rolled through the campground, followed by “Nine Pound Hammer.”

Lake started toward the music.

Ellen caught his arm.

“Sit down.”

“I’m just gonna go watch Patty.”

“You can watch her from here.”

“I can’t see her from here.”

“Then listen.”

Lake sat.

Later Patty came back carrying the fiddle.

“They know good music.”

“How many kids your age know those songs?”

“I don’t care.”

“You’re gonna be eighty years old before you’re twenty.”

“At least I’ll know good music.”

Brooke appeared soaked from head to toe.

Ellen stared at her.

“Did you fall in?”

“I was swimming.”

“You’re not going back.”

“Mom—”

“No.”

Brooke looked at Lake.

He shook his head. “Don’t look at me.”

* * *

Weekend after weekend, they went back.

Brooke found the river and her friends.

Patty found the old-timers and her fiddle.

Lake found things to fool with until Ellen made him sit down.

And Ellen found a chair beside the fire.

Sometimes she fell asleep there.

Lake never woke her.

Nobody called it healing.

They went camping.

That was enough.

* * *

The camper could not stop the years.

One day Brooke came into the room holding out her hand.

“I need to tell y’all something.”

Ellen saw the ring first.

“Oh my God.”

Brooke smiled. “I’m getting married.”

Ellen wrapped her arms around her.

Lake stared at the ring.

“Daddy?”

“I’m processing.”

Brooke laughed.

“You happy?” he asked.

“Yes.”

“You sure?”

“Yes.”

Lake hugged her.

“Then I’m happy.”

Not long after, Patty sat down with news of her own.

“I joined the Navy.”

Lake stared at her.

“You did what?”

“The Navy.”

“The United States Navy?”

Patty rolled her eyes. “No, Daddy. The other Navy.”

Ellen laughed, then her eyes filled.

“I’m proud of you.”

Patty smiled.

Ellen reached for her hand.

“You’re leaving.”

The house had once been full of two little girls.

Brooke with a fishing pole and mud on her shoes.

Patty arguing over schoolwork with a fiddle waiting nearby.

Queenie racing through the yard.

Nana listening.

Campground fires, river water and old songs.

Now Brooke was getting married.

Patty was joining the Navy.
Their girls were leaving home.
And another part of their life was ending.

CHAPTER TWELVE

LEAVING HOME

Brooke's wedding came and went without much fuss.

The ceremony mattered. The marriage mattered. But for Lake, the bigger change came afterward.

The room Brooke had grown up in was suddenly quiet.

Lake stood in the doorway one afternoon.

Ellen found him there.

"She got married, Lake. She didn't disappear."

"I know."

"You're standing in her room like she died."

"I'm just lookin'."

Ellen slipped her hand into his.

"I know."

* * *

Then Brooke became a mother.

Thomas came first.

Lake looked down at his first grandchild and smiled.

Brooke shifted the baby in her arms.

"What's he gonna call you?"

Lake looked at her.

"I don't know."

Later, when Thomas learned to reach for him and call him Poppi, the name stuck.

Lake Farmer was Poppi now.

Little Ellen came after Thomas, Brooke's daughter and the oldest granddaughter, named after her grandmother Ellen.

Thomas and little Ellen became Brooke's world.

* * *

Patty was eighteen when it was her turn to leave.

Lake and Ellen drove her to the big city to catch the bus for basic training.

Patty's bags were in the back.

Lake drove. Ellen sat beside him. Patty sat behind them.

The closer they got to the city, the less anybody talked.

"You got everything?" Lake asked.

"Yes, Daddy."

"Your papers?"

"Yes."

"Everything they told you to bring?"

"Daddy."

"What?"

"I got everything."

Lake nodded and kept driving.

At the pickup point, parents stood beside recruits and luggage.

Then the bus came.

The air brakes hissed.

Ellen whispered, "Oh, God."

She hugged Patty first.

"Call us."

"I will."

"Anytime. I mean it."

“I know, Mom.”

Then Lake pulled Patty against him.

He held on.

“Daddy.”

“Just give me a second.”

Patty held him tighter.

“You call us day or night. I don’t care what time it is.”

“I will.”

“I love you.”

“I love you too, Daddy.”

Patty climbed onto the bus.

She found a window and waved.

Lake and Ellen stood together as it pulled away.

They watched until they could no longer tell which vehicle in the traffic was carrying their daughter.

For eighteen years, they had known where Patty was when they went to bed.

That night they wouldn’t.

* * *

They drove to Great Lakes for her boot camp graduation.

Patty came toward them in Navy whites.

Ellen grabbed her first.

Lake stared.

The same quirky personality was still there, but something had changed. She stood differently. Carried herself differently.

She had grown up while they weren’t looking.

Lake hugged her.

“Missed you.”

“Missed you too, Daddy.”

Leaving her again was hard.

San Diego came next for schooling.

* * *

Patty called from California.

“Daddy, I bought a puppy.”

Lake leaned back.

“You bought a what?”

“A puppy.”

“What kind?”

“Golden retriever.”

“What’d you name him?”

“Soup.”

Lake pulled the phone away and looked at it.

“Soup?”

“Yes.”

From across the room Ellen called, “What’d she name him?”

Lake covered the phone.

“Soup.”

Ellen stared at him.

“Of course she did.”

* * *

Then came orders for Italy.

Patty could not take Soup.

A veteran transported the young golden retriever from California to Missouri.

Lake and Ellen were waiting when he arrived.

Soup bounded toward them, all paws and fur.

Ellen crouched and rubbed both hands through the fur around his neck.

“Patty’s gonna want pictures.”

“We’ll send her some.”

Lake scratched behind Soup’s ear.

“All right, Soup. Come on home.”

Patty went to Italy.

Soup stayed with Lake and Ellen.

Brooke had started her journey.

Patty had started hers.

They had spent years teaching two little girls how to grow up.

Nobody had taught Lake and Ellen how to let them.

And without either of them realizing it, Lake and Ellen were beginning another journey too.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

MYRTLE BEACH

A hospital bracelet around Brooke's wrist read MARCH 2018.

Lake stood beside the bed while Ellen held the newborn.

"Thomas," Brooke said.

Lake leaned closer.

"That's his name?"

"That's his name."

Ellen handed him the baby.

Lake looked down at Thomas.

"Well, buddy. Guess that makes me Poppi."

Brooke smiled.

A computer screen glowed in the living room late one night.

Music played softly from its little speakers.

Lake typed a message.

"Who're you talking to?" Ellen asked.

"That doctor I told you about."

"The one from Myrtle Beach?"

"Yeah. Him and his wife."

Ellen sat beside him.

"What're y'all talking about?"

"Music mostly."

"You got friends on the internet now?"

"Apparently."

Soup walked between them and shoved his head under Ellen's hand.

"Jealous?" Lake asked.

"Of what?"

“My sophisticated online social life.”

“Terribly.”

The messages continued.

Music became stories. Stories became friendship.

Then came the invitation.

“They want us to come to Myrtle Beach,” Lake said.

“For what?”

“Dog sit.”

Ellen stared.

“We’re going to South Carolina to babysit a dog?”

“We already babysit this one.”

Soup thumped his tail.

“Don’t bring him into it,” Ellen said.

* * *

The ocean filled the windshield.

Lake slowed the vehicle.

“Good Lord.”

Ellen turned toward him.

“You’ve seen the ocean before.”

“Not like this.”

He pulled into a beach access.

Soup climbed over the console.

“Get your big butt back there.”

The dog ignored him.

A few minutes later Lake stood barefoot where the water reached the sand.

A wave came in and covered his feet.

He looked down.

Another came.

“Lake.”

He looked at Ellen.

“What?”

“You look five years old.”

He smiled.

“Feels like it.”

Soup charged into the water, jumped backward when the next wave came, then barked at it.

Ellen laughed.

“He thinks he can fight the ocean.”

“He’s my dog.”

* * *

The call came after the storm.

The doctor’s voice sounded tired through the phone.

“We got water under the properties.”

Lake looked across the room at Ellen.

“How bad?”

“Bad enough. I could use another set of hands.”

Lake covered the phone.

“He needs help cleaning up.”

Ellen already knew the look on his face.

“You’re going.”

“Just for a little while.”

“South Carolina is not a little while away.”

Lake looked down at the floor.

“He needs help.”

Ellen nodded.

“Then go help him.”

* * *

The storm was gone by the time Lake reached Myrtle Beach, but it had left itself everywhere.

Water stood in low places. Wet insulation sagged beneath houses. Mud clung to everything.

The doctor stood outside one of the properties with Lake.

“It got under the house.”

“How bad?”

“Bad enough.”

Lake pulled on gloves and crouched beside the opening.

“There are snakes down here,” the doctor said.

Lake looked into the darkness.

“There are snakes in Missouri.”

“That supposed to make this better?”

“Nope.”

Lake crawled under anyway.

Mud soaked through his knees. Wet insulation came down in heavy clumps. Ruined ductwork dragged across the ground behind him.

Something moved near his hand.

Lake jerked backward and struck his shoulder against a beam.

“You all right?” the doctor called.

“Yep.”

“Snake?”

“Nope.”

Lake stared into the dark space where the movement had disappeared.

“You sure?”

“Nope.”

That night the work stopped.

The room where Lake was staying was quiet except for the air conditioner and a television he was not watching.

He sat on the edge of the bed with his phone in his hand.

He called Ellen.

“Hey,” she said.

Lake leaned back against the wall.

“Hey.”

“You sound tired.”

“I am.”

“How bad is it?”

“Mess. Water got everywhere. Pulled wet insulation most of the day.”

“You eat?”

Lake looked at the untouched sandwich on the table.

“Yeah.”

“Liar.”

He smiled for the first time since he had stopped working.

“Maybe.”

There was a pause.

“What’re you doing?” he asked.

“Sitting on the couch.”

“That’s it?”

“That’s it.”

Lake closed his eyes.

He could picture the couch. Ellen’s place on it. The sounds of home that had never seemed like sounds until they were gone.

“I miss you,” he said.

Ellen went quiet for a second.

“You ain’t even been gone that long.”

“Don’t care.”

“I miss you too.”

Lake stayed on the phone.

They talked about nothing important.

That was the important part.

The next morning Lake crawled back beneath the house.

He dragged ruined ductwork toward the opening, twisted, and stopped.

His hand went to his abdomen.

The doctor saw him when he crawled out.

“What’d you do?”

“Nothin’.”

“That didn’t look like nothin’.”

“Pulled somethin’.”

The doctor pointed toward the truck.

“You’re getting that checked.”

“I came down here to work.”

“And I’m telling you to get it checked.”

* * *

The word HERNIA sat on the paperwork.

Lake stared at it, then called Ellen.

“You were right.”

“I usually am. About what?”

“I hurt myself.”

Silence.

“Lake.”

“I’m fine.”

“You just told me you hurt yourself.”

“That don’t mean I ain’t fine.”

“Come home.”

Lake looked out toward the properties still waiting to be cleaned.

“Soon.”

“Lake.”

He smiled.

“I miss you too.”

* * *

The doctor stood with Lake outside another property.

“You ever thought about doing this full time?”

“Crawling under houses?”

“Property work. Painting. Repairs. Keeping places up.”

Lake looked at him.

“Here?”

“Here.”

A lawn mower sat nearby. A pressure washer rested in the back of a truck.

“You serious?”

“I wouldn’t ask if I wasn’t.”

Lake looked toward the road.

“I got a job in Missouri.”

“I know.”

“My family’s there.”

“I know that too.”

The doctor waited.

“Think about it.”

* * *

2018 was printed across the top of the calendar beside the kitchen table.

Lake and Ellen sat at their kitchen table back in Missouri.

Soup lay between their chairs.

“You wanna do it,” Ellen said.

“I don’t know.”

“Yes, you do.”

Lake rubbed his beard-less chin.

“It’s Myrtle Beach.”

“I know where it is.”

“Ocean’s right there.”

“So are hurricanes.”

“There’s work.”

“You have work here.”

Lake looked toward the hallway.

Brooke and Thomas were part of the rhythm of the house now.

“I ain’t askin’ you to decide tonight.”

“You already decided.”

Lake looked at her.

“No.”

“Lake.”

He looked down at Soup.

“Maybe.”

Ellen reached across the table.

“Then we figure it out.”

* * *

Lake left Missouri first.

There was not enough money to move everything at once.

There was not enough certainty to make it feel sensible.

There was only work waiting in South Carolina and the belief that somehow they could make the rest follow.

Ellen stayed behind with Brooke and Thomas.

At night Lake called.

“What’re you doing?”

“Sitting.”

“That sounds exciting.”

“What’re you doing?”

“Missing you.”

Silence.

“Me too,” Ellen said.

Lake looked around the room where he was staying.

“How’s Thomas?”

“Wild.”

“Brooke?”

“Tired.”

“Soup?”

“Looking for you.”

“Tell him I’m working on it.”

“He’s a dog.”

“He understands me better than most people.”

Ellen laughed.

Lake closed his eyes.

* * *

Weeks passed.

Lake painted.

He mowed.

He cleaned.

He repaired whatever the doctor put in front of him.

Money went into an envelope.

Gas.

Food.

Moving truck.

He counted it again.

Then again.

One evening he called Ellen.

“Start packing.”

There was a pause.

“What?”

“I got enough.”

“Enough for what?”

“Truck.”

Ellen went quiet.

“You serious?”

“I’m coming home to get you.”

* * *

The moving truck sat outside in Missouri with its back door open.

Boxes filled the rooms that had once felt crowded with people.

Now every box carried something away.

Brooke stood near the doorway with Thomas on her hip while Ellen made one more trip through the house.

Lake carried a box outside, set it in the truck and came back in.

Brooke was still standing in the same place.

“That it?” she asked.

Lake looked around.

“Almost.”

Thomas stretched both arms toward him.

"Poppi."

Lake stopped.

He took the little boy from Brooke and held him against his chest.

"You gonna take care of everybody while I'm gone?"

Thomas touched Lake's beard.

"Poppi go?"

Lake swallowed.

"Yeah, buddy. Poppi's gotta go."

Thomas laid his head against Lake's shoulder.

Lake shut his eyes and held him tighter.

Fifteen hours.

He had driven farther than that before. Miles had never bothered him much when there was a road underneath him.

This felt different.

Brooke wiped beneath one eye.

"Dad."

Lake opened his eyes.

"What?"

"You're gonna make me cry."

"I ain't doin' nothin'."

"Exactly."

Ellen came from the hallway and reached for Thomas.

He went to her, then immediately wrapped both arms around her neck.

Ellen buried her face against him.

Nobody said anything.

Lake looked toward the open front door.

The truck waited outside.

Brooke looked at Ellen.

“You call me when you get there.”

“I will.”

“And before you get there.”

Ellen laughed through wet eyes.

“I will.”

She handed Thomas back.

His fingers caught her shirt and held for a second before slipping free.

Ellen turned away quickly.

Brooke hugged Lake.

He wrapped both arms around her.

“Take care of yourself,” he said.

“You too.”

“And him.”

Brooke pulled back.

“Dad, he’s my son.”

“I know. I’m still allowed to say it.”

She smiled, but her mouth trembled.

Lake touched Thomas’s head one last time.

“Poppi loves you.”

Outside, Lake climbed into the truck. Ellen got in beside him. Soup settled between them as if the whole move had been arranged for his convenience.

Lake started the engine.

He did not put it in gear.

Through the windshield Brooke stood in the yard holding Thomas.

Thomas lifted one hand.

Lake lifted his.

Then he put the truck in gear.

Ellen watched them in the side mirror until the road bent and they disappeared.

Lake reached across Soup and found her hand.

Neither of them spoke for several miles.

The highway signs pointed east.

Every mile made Brooke and Thomas farther away.

The doctor's house smelled like fresh paint.

Lake stood in the middle of the living room with a roller in his hand.

Ellen walked in carrying grocery bags.

"You painted this room again?"

"Needed another coat."

"You said that yesterday."

"Yesterday it needed the first another coat."

She set the bags down.

"I cleaned three houses today."

Lake looked at her hands.

Dirt remained around one thumbnail.

"Thought you were gardening."

"Did that too."

Lake put the roller down.

"You hate it."

"It's work."

"That ain't what I said."

Ellen opened a cabinet.

"We need money."

Lake watched her.

"You had an office in Missouri."

"Lake."

"You did."

"And now I don't."

He picked up the roller.

"I'm sorry."

Ellen turned.

“For what?”

“All this.”

She looked around the half-renovated room.

“I came with you.”

“Because I asked.”

“Because I wanted to be with you.”

Soup walked in carrying one of Lake’s socks.

“Drop it.”

Soup ran.

Ellen laughed.

“Go get your child.”

* * *

Soup waited at the door when Lake and Ellen came home.

He waited at the door.

He followed Ellen from room to room.

He slept close enough to Lake that Lake regularly woke with no blanket.

“Move.”

Soup sighed.

“You got the whole floor.”

Soup did not move.

“Ellen.”

“He’s asleep.”

“He’s on my leg.”

“Then don’t move your leg.”

Lake stared at the ceiling.

“We raised two daughters and now I’m gettin’ bossed around by a dog.”

Soup thumped his tail once.

* * *

Ellen came through the door one afternoon holding papers.

“I got it.”

Lake looked up from a paint tray.

“Got what?”

“Office job.”

He stood.

“Where?”

“Homeowners association management.”

“You serious?”

She smiled.

“I’m serious.”

Lake hugged her, paint still on one hand.

“Lake!”

“What?”

“You got paint on me.”

He looked at the mark.

“Looks good.”

“You are an idiot.”

She kissed him.

Before the HOA position, an accountant gave Ellen enough work to bridge the gap.

Then the front desk and office clothes returned.

Lake kept painting.

He mowed properties.

He cleaned.

He took outside painting jobs.

He pressure-washed driveways, houses and anything else somebody would pay him to clean.

At the end of the day, he and Ellen loaded Soup into the vehicle.

“Beach?” Lake asked.

“Beach.”

* * *

The Atlantic was dark blue under the evening sky.

Soup pulled at the leash.

“Slow down, fool.”

Ellen took off her shoes.

Lake carried his.

They walked where the water flattened the sand.

Soup chased foam and backed away from every returning wave as though surprised it had come back.

“He still ain’t figured it out,” Ellen said.

“Neither have I.”

“What?”

Lake looked toward the horizon.

“That we live this close to this.”

Ellen looked at him.

Lake smiled.

“Poor kid from Missouri standing in the Atlantic Ocean after work.”

“You’re standing beside it.”

“Close enough.”

Soup lunged at a gull.

“And our idiot son is trying to catch birds.”

Ellen laughed.

Lake took her hand.

They kept walking.

* * *

The phone calls home were harder on some nights.

Brooke put Thomas on video.

“Poppi!”

“Hey, buddy!”

“When you comin’ home?”

Lake looked at Ellen.

She was already looking away.

“Soon as we can.”

“Tomorrow?”

Lake smiled.

“Wish I could.”

After the call, Ellen sat quietly.

“You okay?”

“Yep.”

Lake waited.

“No.”

He sat beside her.

“I miss them.”

“I know.”

“Brooke needs us.”

“I know.”

Soup put his head across Ellen’s lap.

She rubbed his ears.

“He knows.”

“He always knows.”

* * *

Lake rolled the last coat of paint onto the final room.

Fresh paint covered the walls.

Repairs were finished.

The doctor's house no longer needed Lake and Ellen living inside it to make it whole.

Lake and Ellen sat at the kitchen table.

"We can't buy anything here," Ellen said.

Lake looked at listings on his phone.

"Not unless you wanna live in a shed."

"How big a shed?"

"Don't encourage me."

The phone rang.

Dale.

Lake answered.

"Hey."

He listened.

Ellen watched his face.

"Yeah."

Another pause.

"You serious?"

Lake looked at Ellen.

"All right. Lemme talk to her."

He ended the call.

"What?" Ellen asked.

Lake set the phone on the table.

"Your dad and Sue said if we come home, they'll help us get a house."

Ellen stared at him.

Soup's tail tapped the floor.

"A house?"

"Our house."

The ocean was only a short drive away.

Brooke and Thomas were hundreds of miles in the other direction.

Ellen reached across the table.

"I wanna go home."

Lake nodded.

"Okay."

* * *

The U-Haul was full.

The wallet was not.

Lake stood at the gas pump and watched the numbers climb.

Ellen leaned out the window.

“How much we got left?”

“Enough.”

“That wasn’t my question.”

Lake replaced the nozzle.

“Enough to get home.”

“And after that?”

He climbed in.

“We’ll figure it out.”

Soup sat between them.

Lake started the truck.

“Heard that before,” Ellen said.

“Worked so far.”

* * *

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

COMING HOME

The U-Haul receipt on the dashboard was dated MAY 2020.

Ellen carried a box into Brooke's house.

Thomas, two years old now, followed her through the room.

Brooke sat on the couch with a newborn wrapped against her chest.

Ellen set the box down.

"Give me that baby."

Brooke smiled and handed her over.

Lake leaned over Ellen's shoulder.

"There's Ellen."

Brooke looked at her mother.

"Named her after you."

Ellen looked down at the baby again.

"Well, now she has to behave."

Lake smiled.

"Poor kid never had a chance."

Ellen touched the baby's cheek.

Lake looked around at the boxes.

"I'm headed to Dale and Sue's."

Ellen looked up at him.

"I know."

"Two months. Tops."

"You better hope so."

Help-wanted searches filled Lake's phone screen, followed by unanswered applications.

It did not greet them with a house.

Ellen moved in with Brooke, Thomas and newborn Ellen.

Lake moved in with Dale and Sue.

At night Lake called Ellen from a different bed in a different house.

“This is stupid.”

“Yep.”

“We moved home so we could live apart.”

“Temporarily.”

“I hate temporarily.”

“Me too.”

Lake looked at listings.

“Found one for sixty-eight.”

“Where?”

He told her.

“No.”

“You ain’t even seen it.”

“I know where it is.”

“House looks good.”

“Lake.”

“Seventy’s about all we got to work with.”

Silence.

“Fine,” Ellen said. “We’ll look.”

* * *

The little rural house was clean.

The yard was kept.

Doors closed properly.

Cabinets were solid.

Nothing smelled wet.

Nothing leaned.

Lake opened a closet.

“Look at this.”

“It’s a closet.”

“It’s a good closet.”

Ellen stared through the window.

“I still don’t wanna live in this town.”

“I know.”

“It’s small.”

“I know.”

“There ain’t anything here.”

“There’s a house.”

Ellen looked at him.

Lake put his hand on the wall.

“And this one’s ours if we want it.”

Ellen looked around again.

“You really like it?”

“I like you in it.”

She shook her head.

“That was terrible.”

“Did it work?”

She smiled.

* * *

The closing papers were dated JULY 2020.

Lake slid the key across the table toward Ellen.

“Home.”

Ellen closed her fingers around it.

“Maybe.”

* * *

Masks hung from rearview mirrors and signs covered business doors.

Masks hung from rearview mirrors.

Businesses had signs taped to doors.

Job applications went unanswered.

Lake finally came home with news.

“I got something.”

“What?” Ellen asked.

“DME company. Delivering oxygen.”

“Pay?”

Lake told her.

Ellen made a face.

“I know.”

“Hours?”

“Sounds like all of ’em.”

The phone started proving him right.

Oxygen cylinders clanged together in the truck.

Addresses came one after another.

Lake pulled into driveways at night.

People waited behind doors wearing masks.

Family members waved him inside and pointed toward bedrooms.

Televisions carried case counts and hospital reports.

Lake rolled oxygen through living rooms.

“Put it right here.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

“Thank you for coming.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

His phone rang before he reached the truck.

“This is Lake.”

Another address.

Another tank.

Another house.

Another night.

At home Ellen waited with food that had gone cold.

“You eat?”

“Not yet.”

“Sit down.”

Lake sat.

The phone rang.

He looked at it.

Ellen looked at him.

Lake answered.

“This is Lake.”

* * *

For a year, the calendar pages turned while the DME phone kept ringing.

Lake set a thick stack of delivery slips beside a thin pay stub.

Ellen found medical billing work.

One evening they sat at the table with pay stubs and bills.

“That all?” Lake asked.

“That’s all.”

He looked at his stub.

“I worked how many hours?”

“Too many.”

“And made that?”

Ellen reached across the table.

“We’re paying the house.”

“Barely.”

“But we’re paying it.”

Lake looked around the little room.

Soup slept beneath the table.

Lake nodded.

“Yeah.”

* * *

Lake called a man he had known for years.

“You got anything?”

The answer brought him back toward trucks.

Inside parts sales at Peterbilt.

Not the road.

Not exactly what he wanted.

But the first morning he stood behind a parts counter again, he picked up a phone.

“Parts, this is Lake.”

A customer described a problem.

Lake reached for a catalog.

“What truck you workin’ on?”

Lake’s hand moved from catalog to keyboard to phone.

Part numbers.

Customers.

Problems.

Solutions.

He hung up and looked at the counter.

“Well, hell.”

A coworker looked over.

“What?”

“I remember this.”

* * *

Ellen moved from medical billing into administration for a nursing-home company.

Two pay stubs lay beside the bills on the table.

The refrigerator stayed full.

Bills got paid closer to the date printed on them.

Patty came back from Italy with stories and someone in those stories who did not disappear.

The man she had met there became her husband.

* * *

A phone screen lit Lake's face in JUNE 2023.

Patty held a newborn toward the camera.

"Can you see her?"

Lake leaned closer.

"I see her."

"Rose."

"Hey, Rose. Poppi's the handsome one."

Ellen shouted from across the room.

"Don't lie to that baby."

Patty laughed through the phone.

Patty and her husband settled in South Carolina. Patty's work badge read MANAGER beneath the name of a medical office.

Brooke remarried.

Her home held two children now.

The phone rang again.

Phones rang with arguments and court dates.

Adult voices dropped when children entered rooms.

Lake sat beside Brooke at the table one evening.

"I'm tired, Daddy."

Lake put his hand over hers.

"I know."

"It never stops."

"Then we keep goin'."

Brooke looked at him.

“That your answer for everything?”

“Pretty much.”

She leaned against him.

Lake rested his cheek against the top of her head.

* * *

Near the end of Lake’s second year behind the Peterbilt parts counter, a conversation with a coworker turned bad.

A conversation with a coworker turned bad.

Voices rose.

Lake pushed away from the counter.

“I’m done.”

Someone called after him.

Lake kept walking.

The door closed behind him.

Days later, a razor sat untouched.

Then weeks.

Stubble became a beard.

Dark strands gave way to white.

Lake sat on the porch one afternoon.

Ellen came outside.

“You gonna shave that thing?”

Lake rubbed the growing beard.

“Maybe.”

“You’ve been saying maybe for a month.”

Lake looked toward the road.

“Don’t feel like doin’ much of anything.”

Ellen sat beside him.

Soup put his head across Lake’s knee.

“He likes it,” Lake said.

“He eats garbage.”

Lake smiled for the first time that day.

* * *

A 2023 calendar hung behind the phone when it rang.

The phone call about Freightliner came later.

Outside sales.

Lake sat straighter.

“Outside?”

He listened.

“Yeah. Yeah, I’m interested.”

Ellen watched him from the kitchen.

When the call ended, she raised her eyebrows.

“Well?”

Lake smiled beneath the white beard.

“I think I’m goin’ back on the road.”

The Freightliner sales vehicle rolled from one customer to the next.

Lake drove from customer to customer.

His phone rang constantly.

Parts questions came faster than he could write them down.

He carried cores.

He looked up numbers.

He solved problems in parking lots and shops.

One customer waved as Lake pulled in.

“There he is!”

Lake climbed out.

“What’d you break now?”

“That’s why I called you.”

Lake laughed.

Later, driving between stops, he looked through the windshield and smiled.

Lake drummed his fingers on the steering wheel as another customer's name appeared on the phone.

He answered with a grin.

* * *

Ellen landed a job at an agricultural fertilizer plant.

The money was good.

For a while, Lake and Ellen could look at each other without every conversation ending in a bill.

Then the plant went out of business.

Ellen came home with a box.

Lake looked at it.

"No."

She nodded.

"Closed."

"Whole place?"

"Whole place."

Lake took the box from her.

"Well."

"Don't say it."

"Say what?"

"We'll figure it out."

Lake smiled.

"Wasn't gonna say that."

"Liar."

* * *

She found another good job.

A textile manufacturing plant only a few miles from the house.

Newer building.

Front desk.

Administrator.

One morning Lake stood at the door while Ellen picked up her bag.

“How long’s your drive?”

“Few minutes.”

“Must be nice.”

“You chose outside sales.”

“I did.”

She kissed him.

“Go sell something.”

“Go administrate something.”

She laughed and left.

* * *

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

2024

SEPTEMBER 2024 was printed on Ellen's hospital wristband.

Lake sat beside her bed while a monitor blinked.

Ellen looked at him.

"Quit staring at that thing."

"I ain't staring."

"You've watched every beep for twenty minutes."

Lake looked at the monitor again.

"It keeps beepin'."

"That's what it's supposed to do."

A nurse stepped in.

"Ready for the ablation?"

Ellen reached for Lake's hand.

He took it.

The night before, Lake's phone lit up with Collette's name.

He looked at it.

Work had worn him down. Ellen's heart procedure was still hanging over both of them, and he did not feel like settling into one of those long conversations with his mother.

The phone kept ringing.

"You gonna get that?" Ellen asked.

Lake turned the screen facedown.

"I'll call her tomorrow."

The ringing stopped.

* * *

OCTOBER 2024 was printed on the corner of Lake's sales-route sheet.

Lake was on his sales route when Punkin called.

He answered through the truck.

"Hey, Punk—"

Her scream cut him off.

"Mom is dead!"

Lake's hand tightened around the steering wheel.

"What?"

"Mom is dead!"

He pulled off the road.

"What do you mean?"

Punkin cried into the phone.

Lake stared through the windshield.

Traffic moved past.

His phone screen changed when the call ended.

He opened the recent calls.

Collette's name was there.

From the night before.

Missed call.

Lake touched the screen.

He sat alone in the Freightliner sales vehicle while trucks passed on the highway.

His phone remained in his hand.

He pressed Collette's name.

The call went nowhere that mattered.

Lake lowered the phone.

His white beard moved against his chest when he covered his face with both hands.

* * *

He could still see her name on the screen.

One call. One swipe he had not made.

He had believed there would be another night, another drive, another chance to hear his mother talk longer than he felt like listening.

Now there was no tomorrow to call her back.

When he finally called Ellen, he could barely get the words out.

“Momma’s gone.”

Ellen went quiet.

Lake stared through the windshield.

“She called me last night.”

“Lake…”

“I didn’t answer.”

Traffic kept moving past the parked sales vehicle.

“I didn’t answer her.”

* * *

Ellen’s second hospital wristband read NOVEMBER 2024.

Lake sat in the same kind of chair beside another hospital bed.

Ellen looked at him.

“You’re doing it again.”

“What?”

“Watching the monitor.”

Lake looked away from it.

“I got reasons.”

Ellen reached across the blanket.

Lake took her hand.

A nurse opened the door.

“We’re ready.”

Lake squeezed Ellen’s fingers before letting go.

* * *

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

THREE-QUARTERS GREEN

Lake's phone rang.

He looked at the screen.

Daddy.

Lake answered.

"Hey, Daddy."

"Whatcha doin'?"

"Nothin'."

"You at work?"

"No. I'm home."

"Well, then you ain't doin' nothin'."

Lake smiled.

"I reckon not."

Alan laughed.

Across the room, Ellen looked over.

Lake pointed at the phone and mouthed, "Daddy."

She smiled.

* * *

They talked about work. The weather. Family. The grandkids. Thomas. Little Ellen. Rose. Rain.

The conversation wandered wherever it wanted to. Neither man seemed in a hurry to end it.

After a while, Lake leaned back.

"Daddy?"

"Yeah?"

"You remember that old trailer?"

“What trailer?”

Lake smiled. “You know what trailer.”

A pause. Then Alan laughed.

“That old damn thing?”

“Yep.”

“The green one?”

“Three-quarters green.”

“Didn’t have enough paint.”

“I remember.”

“Paint was free.”

“I remember that too.”

“Ain’t nothin’ wrong with free paint.”

“Nope.”

“Made that place look pretty good.”

“Three-quarters of it.”

Alan laughed. “Other quarter looked all right.”

“Daddy, it looked terrible.”

“Nah.”

“It was rusty white.”

“Still stood.”

Lake’s smile faded. He looked toward the window.

“Yeah.”

Alan’s voice softened.

“Still stood.”

* * *

“You remember those boards you put underneath it?”

“What boards?”

“The particle board.”

“Oh, hell.”

Lake laughed. “That looked terrible too.”

“Kept the wind out.”

“Some of it.”

“Did the job.”

“I reckon.”

“And that wall I put up in y’all’s room.”

“Me and Punkin.”

“Yeah.”

“We didn’t even have beds.”

“You had somewhere to sleep.”

“On the floor.”

“Floor worked.”

Lake laughed. “Daddy, you can make anything sound good.”

“Ain’t nobody died.”

“That’s your standard?”

“Pretty good standard.”

Lake laughed harder.

* * *

“Daddy?”

“Yeah?”

“You remember tellin’ me to wash my hands in the zinc?”

“The what?”

“The zinc.”

“That’s what I said.”

“No. You said zinc.”

“I said zinc.”

Lake laughed. “You’re still doin’ it.”

“Doin’ what?”

“Nothin’.”

For a moment, Lake could see that little kitchen again. Jimmy Swaggart on the television. Momma moving around the room.

Punkin nearby. Daddy coming through the door.

"Wash 'em good in the zinc."

"Sink, Alan."

"That's what I said."

"You said zinc."

"I said zinc."

Lake smiled. Then he went quiet.

"Daddy?"

"Yeah?"

"I miss Momma."

Silence came from the other end.

"Yeah," Alan finally said.

"I miss her bad."

"I know, son."

Lake rubbed his thumb along the edge of the phone.

"I keep thinkin' about her callin' me that night."

Alan waited.

"I wish I'd answered."

"I know."

Lake looked down.

Then Alan said, "She knew you loved her."

Lake closed his eyes.

"Yeah."

"You know that, don't you?"

Lake swallowed. "Yeah."

* * *

After a moment, Lake spoke again.

"Daddy?"

"What?"

"I think I'm gonna write a book one day."

Alan laughed. “You?”

“What’s that supposed to mean?”

“Nothin’. What you gonna write a book about?”

“Us.”

“Us?”

“Yeah. You. Momma. Me and Punkin. That old trailer. All of it.”

Alan was quiet.

“The tornado. All them jobs. Ellen. Brooke and Patty. Nana. The grandkids. Everything.”

“Well, hell.”

Lake laughed. “What?”

Alan paused. Then his voice softened.

“Son, tell it just like you saw it.”

Lake went still.

“Don’t change a thing. It’s a hell of a story.”

Lake looked down at his hands.

“Your Momma would be so proud.”

Lake’s eyes filled.

“I hope so.”

“She would.”

Lake wiped his eyes.

“Love you, Daddy.”

“Love you too, son.”

“Talk to you later.”

“Yep.”

The call ended.

Lake looked at the screen for a moment before setting the phone down.

* * *

Ellen walked over.

“How’s Daddy?”

“He’s Daddy.”

“That good, huh?”

“Yeah.”

She sat beside him.

“What were you two laughing about?”

“That old trailer.”

“The green one?”

“Three-quarters green.”

“I’ve heard about it.”

“Daddy still thinks it looked good.”

“Did it?”

“No.”

Ellen laughed. Lake did too.

“I told him I might write a book.”

Ellen raised an eyebrow. “A book?”

“Yeah.”

“About what?”

Lake looked at her. “Us. All of it.”

Ellen smiled. “You better make me look good.”

“Daddy told me not to change anything.”

Ellen narrowed her eyes. “Lake.”

He laughed.

* * *

Later that night, the house was dark.

Lake lay awake beside Ellen. She slept facing him.

He looked at her. Really looked at her.

Gray had found its way into her curly brown hair. Wrinkles rested around her eyes.

Lake reached over and moved a strand of hair from her face. She stirred but didn’t wake.

For a moment, he could see the sixteen-year-old girl walking through the door at Taco John's. Curly brown hair. Hazel-brown eyes. That smile he thought could light up a dark cave.

Then he looked at the woman beside him. The gray. The wrinkles. The years.

Lake smiled.

They had earned every one of them together.

He wouldn't have traded a single wrinkle or gray hair to have the sixteen-year-old girl back.

That girl hadn't lived their life yet.

This woman had.

Lake brushed his thumb gently beside her eye.

He remembered asking her to marry him after only three months.

Back then, the rest of their lives had sounded like forever.

Now the rest of their lives was lying beside him.

Lake leaned over and kissed her forehead.

"You're beautiful," he whispered.

Ellen moved a little closer in her sleep.

Lake smiled. "Love you."

He settled against the pillow.

Daddy's words came back to him.

Tell it just like you saw it.

Lake closed his eyes.

And sometime during the night, he dreamed.

* * *

Lake was running through grass beneath a warm summer sun.

Ahead of him stood a little twelve-by-sixty trailer. Weathered white on one end. Mint green across the other three-quarters.

Lake slowed.

The door opened.

Momma stepped outside.

Lake stopped.

Young. Smiling. Alive.

“Lake!”

His face crumpled.

“Momma!”

He ran.

Collette came down the pallet steps and opened her arms.

Lake fell into them. He buried his face against her shoulder.

“I missed you, Momma.”

She held him tight. “I know, baby.”

“I missed you so bad.”

“I know.”

“I love you.”

“I love you too, son.”

Lake pulled back and looked at her. Tears ran down his face.

“I’m sorry.”

Momma touched his cheek. “For what?”

“That night.”

Lake’s voice broke. “You called me.”

She waited.

“I saw your name.”

Lake looked down. “I should’ve answered.”

Momma wiped a tear from his cheek.

“I thought I had more time.”

She pulled him against her.

“I’m sorry, Momma.”

“Son, look at me.”

Lake raised his head.

Momma smiled. “I’ve always been right here.”

Lake shook his head. “I couldn’t see you.”

She placed her hand against his chest. “You didn’t have to.”

Lake covered her hand with his.

Behind Momma, the trailer door stood open. Warm light spilled across the pallet steps.

Lake looked toward it. Then back at her.

“Can I come in?”

Momma’s smile softened. “Not yet.”

Lake’s eyes filled again. “Why?”

She took his hands. “It ain’t your time, son.”

“But I just got you back.”

“You never lost me.”

Lake wrapped his arms around her. “I don’t wanna leave.”

“I know.”

“I wanna stay with you.”

“I know, baby.”

Momma kissed his forehead. “But you got people waitin’ on you.”

Lake closed his eyes. Ellen. Brooke. Patty. Thomas. Little Ellen. Rose. Rain. Daddy.

Momma rubbed his back. “You go love ’em.”

Lake held her tighter. “And when it is my time?”

Momma looked back at the little trailer. Then at her son.

“I’ll be right here.”

Lake stared at her. “Promise?”

She smiled. “Promise.”

Lake wrapped his arms around her one last time.

“I love you, Momma.”

“I love you too, son.”

The sunlight began to fade.

Lake tried to hold on.

“Momma?”

“I’m right here.”

The grass disappeared beneath his feet.

“Momma!”

“I’m right here, baby.”

The little trailer grew farther away.

“Momma!”

Her voice followed him.

“I’m right here.”

* * *

Lake woke with a gasp.

The bedroom was dark.

His face was wet.

Tears.

For a moment, he could still feel Momma’s arms around him. Still hear her voice.

I’ll be right here.

Lake covered his face and cried.

Beside him, Ellen stirred.

“Lake?”

He wiped his eyes and turned toward her.

“I’m here.”

“You okay?”

Lake looked at her. The gray in her curls. The wrinkles around those hazel-brown eyes. All those years.

He smiled through the tears.

"Yeah."

Ellen reached for his hand. Lake took it.

"You sure?"

He nodded. "Yeah."

He looked at his wife.

Then, for just a moment, he saw Momma standing beside the pallet steps. Young. Smiling. Waiting outside that little twelve-by-sixty trailer.

Not yet.

Lake looked back at Ellen.

He squeezed her hand.

And smiled.

Three-quarters green.